

Q How do you see other universities following the trend started by you?

As mentioned earlier, universities the world over (possibly not all for the same set of reasons) have little choice with respect to moving more and more of their teaching-learning processes online and adopting the 'distance mode' in a phased manner. You must have seen the recent announcement from MIT, Boston, about its own online programmes, though they are not degree-oriented, as of now. So we at Anna University are proud that we are the first major public university in our country coming out with a fully online learning programme leading to a degree. We would be quite pleased to see other universities moving in the same direction, though I must hasten to add that our university systems and processes took about two years of rigorous scrutiny and due diligence before the programme could be launched.

Q Are there any steps you would like the government to take in this direction?

As we are bound to run into steep gradients on the learning curve in making this programme viable (financially, academically, socially, etc) some support from appropriate government agencies like MHRD, DIT, etc, would help in making this 'concept proving' round successful. I am sure we will be speaking with all the relevant bodies in the government and in industry to share our experiences with them so that they could take a call on this.

Q There is a dearth of teachers in the FOSS ecosystem as well. Do you have any plans to address this issue?

Do you mean a FOSS teacher training/certification programme offered online for university/college teachers? Yes, we would always be ready to offer this, provided the numbers add up to make it financially viable.

Q Apart from this initiative, in the past, have there been other efforts from AU to promote FOSS?

From what has been said, you would have gathered that the real bottleneck in the growth of FOSS in India is inadequate and commercially sustainable deployment with 'real world users' – beyond the campuses and research labs. Some of our work in this area is already reported on the NRCFOSS/AU-KBC website. To illustrate, the entire interactive online content delivery platform from which the M.Sc (CS-FOSS) courses will be delivered is being built purely with state-of-the-art FOSS technologies.

Q What do you think is a major hindrance in the adoption of open source software in India?

At the outset, we really don't seem to have authentic figures that prove that this is indeed the case! Surely, a fair amount of FOSS is being used in India by various people. But I agree with the spirit behind your query; perhaps it is no more due to the lack of awareness as it was, say, till about five years ago, especially in urban centres where most of

software/IT work is still concentrated. There doesn't seem to be a clear short to medium term economic advantage of adequate value to motivate many companies to move to FOSS, wholeheartedly. The free availability of unlicensed software would also be a contributory factor for it.

"FOSS promotion in its 'pure and unadulterated' form is not the only objective of our online programme"

Q How do you see the open source ecosystem evolving in the country?

Our industry alone can be the real game-changer in this. If our software/IT industry (both the big and small firms) starts using FOSS in a major way (for very sound economic reasons), that will drive the HR need in this field which the universities will then step in to meet. But this is a tough scene in which to make predictions—what with many disruptive technologies coming out routinely, such as cloud computing!

Q What are the real challenges in the implementation of open source technology and how can one overcome them?

This is based on the situation and context, and one can only list the whole range of obstacles that could be at work. The challenges are—awareness, availability of skillsets (and cost) of migration, visible and obvious short to medium term financial gains, the confidence of clients, the newness and uncertainties related to dealing with the constantly evolving FOSS technologies, the question of who will provide steady and dependable service, etc.

Q Open source is often questioned when it comes to security (not that proprietary software are safe). What are your comments on this issue?

While there is such a perception going around, it may not be as serious as it is made out to be. In proprietary software, you do not know what you are getting, how secure the software is and hence your systems are, as far as YOU are concerned (and not the vendor!). So, proprietary software having better security is a bit of a myth. Unless we're talking about a 'sense of security', which implies an ignorance of threats and vulnerabilities – of one living in the proverbial fool's paradise, as it were.

In FOSS, if you have acute concerns regarding security, then you can always get someone to check everything possible ('everything' is never possible in the security field, I must confess!) and tell you what could go wrong. At the very least, you will surely know what you are getting into.

I agree, it is probably not a black/white case, but in most cases I don't feel security need be a major factor preventing migration to FOSS if there are other compelling reasons. Here again, such opinions and views ought to be very situation and context specific. 